



Episode 4 - Hustle Culture

In this week's episode, we take a proper look at hustle culture: the grind, the burnout, and the big question everyone's asking right now, which is whether the whole thing is finally on its way out.

Along the way, we explore natural English vocabulary and expressions all about work, ambition, exhaustion and switching off, from the daily grind and burning out, to the modern backlash of quiet quitting and the soft life.

I've highlighted the key phrases and idioms to help boost your English, improve your listening, and give you really useful language you can start using in everyday conversation. You'll also hear two friends, Johnny and Mary, putting the language to work in a natural chat.

You'll find the full transcript and vocabulary notes on the pages that follow.

Thank you for tuning in, and enjoy the episode!

TRANSCRIPT

Hello and welcome back to Johncast, the English Language Learning Podcast for curious minds and, this week, slightly tired ones. Because today we're taking a proper look at hustle culture: the grind, the burn-out, and the big question everyone's asking right now, which is whether the whole thing is finally on its way out.

And as always, along the way I'll be exploring a whole range of really useful English vocabulary, all about work, ambition, exhaustion and switching off. This is the kind of natural, idiomatic language that fluent speakers reach for without even thinking about it, so it's exactly the sort of thing that will make you sound that little bit more natural yourself. I'll drop each phrase into the first half of the podcast, and then in the second half we'll slow right down and unpack them one by one, with little stories behind them so they actually stick in your head. So grab a notebook, or just sit back and relax, which is a little bit ironic given the topic, and let's get into it.

So, **hustle culture**. The pronunciation is important: hustle. Hustle culture refers to a mindset that glorifies constant work, long hours and relentless, non-stop productivity, while at the same time treating rest and relaxation as laziness. I'm sure you're familiar with this, because it's been around for about ten years now, and the message has always been the same: work harder, sleep less. Being busy became something to be proud of, and if you weren't exhausted, well, you clearly just weren't working hard enough.

Personally, I think it peaked in the last year or two. Our social media feeds were full of it, right? Full of podcasters, millionaire entrepreneurs filming themselves at the gym at four o'clock in the morning, motivational quotes everywhere, and that whole "**no days off**" kind of vibe. And it got into everything, not just work but study, fitness, hobbies, even relationships.

Suddenly you weren't allowed to just enjoy the simple things in life; you had to turn it into a side business, or as they say, **a side hustle**.

But here's the thing. It's 2026 now, and I think people are finally realising that this whole culture of **hustling** and **grinding** is overrated, and the conversation has started to turn around. I'm sure you'll agree, we're all sick and tired of hyper-productivity and trying to maximise every waking hour.

This week I was reading through a few articles on this, and they were all asking the very same question: **is hustle culture actually dead?**

Well, it seems so, and honestly the numbers back it up. Gallup, the big research company, found that 36% of Gen Z feel engaged at work, and this is the lowest of any generation. Another survey found that 83% of Gen Z said they were **burnt out**, compared to 75% of everyone else. Now, many people will be sceptical of these data, because they'll say, oh well, younger generations, they have the wrong priorities, blah blah blah. But I think younger people are willing to prioritise work-life balance now, and to say enough is enough when it comes to hustle culture. I just think young people are not buying it anymore. They're joining the workforce and saying, look, previous generations are exhausted, stressed, working 24/7 practically, and instead they're saying, no thank you, that is not the life I want for myself.

But this gets to the very heart of what hustle culture is: the glorification of work. I'm not saying we don't have to work hard; it's just that **work-life balance** should be a priority for all of us, especially in 2026. It's about finding that balance between working hard, doing your bit, and the so-called **soft life**. So I'd really love to know what you make of all of this. Is hustle culture dead where you live, or is it still very much alive and well? And I'm also curious to know your opinion on these surveys among Gen Z. Do you think they're right, and that prioritising work-life balance is a must? Or do you feel they're embracing the soft life a bit too much?

Now, this is the perfect opportunity to dive into some genuinely useful English vocabulary, all about work, burnout and switching off. But before we do so, I want you to listen to two friends, Johnny and Mary (very imaginative names) having a chat about hustle culture and burnout. Don't worry if you don't catch every single word, just sit back, relax, and see how many of today's phrases you can spot along the way. So, here we go.

JOHNNY & MARY

Mary: Sorry I'm late! I've been up since the crack of dawn. Honestly, I'm burning the candle at both ends at the minute.

Johnny: You look exhausted, Mary. Properly burnt out.

Mary: I am. I've got so much on my plate, work, the side hustle, the gym. I'm juggling the lot and it's honestly a lot.

Johnny: That's the rat race for you. You're going to run yourself into the ground.

Mary: Maybe. But you don't get anywhere doing the bare minimum, do you? Rise and grind, that's what I say.

Johnny: See, I used to think exactly like that. Total workaholic. All work and no play. And I burnt out, completely.

Mary: So what changed?

Johnny: I gave up the hustle. Now I'm all about the soft life. Proper work-life balance, and yes, bare minimum Mondays.

Mary: Isn't that just quiet quitting, though?

Johnny: Call it what you like. I've stopped buying into all that toxic productivity. I actually switch off now, recharge my batteries of an evening.

Mary: I honestly can't remember the last time I wound down.

Johnny: That's exactly it, Mary. You don't have to run yourself into the ground to prove you're worth something.

Mary: ...Maybe you've got a point.

Johnny: Come on, coffee's on me. Consider it your first proper break.

Thank you, Johnny and Mary, for that wonderful conversation. So, how many did you manage to catch? Don't worry if it wasn't many, because that's exactly what we're here for: to break it all down, piece by piece.

WORD HISTORY

Now, before we get into the vocabulary itself, let me give you a quick bit of etymology, or word history, because the two words at the centre of all this, **hustle** and **grind**, have interesting stories behind them.

Take **hustle** first. It comes from an old Dutch word, "husselen", which simply meant "to shake". In fact, when it first came into English in the 17th century, it literally meant to shake something forward and back, and there was even a little gambling game called hustle-cap, where you'd shake coins around in a hat. From there it grew, from shaking, to pushing, to hurrying, and finally to working hard.

But here's the interesting part. From the very start, hustle also meant to cheat somebody, or to con somebody out of money, and that double life never really left the word. So even today, when you call someone a **hustler**, it can be a compliment, as in they work hard, or it can be an insult, meaning you don't really trust them, because they're trying to con you or deceive you.

On top of that, we have many phrases that use the word hustle. For example, **hustle and bustle**, which refers to the noise and activity of a busy place, so the hustling there is about movement, coming from that idea of shaking. And a **side hustle** refers to a side job you have apart from your main job, doing a bit of extra work to earn a bit of money.

Now, **grind** is a much older, much heavier word, if I can put it that way. It comes from Old English, "grindan," meaning to crush something into powder, like when you grind coffee beans, or grind grain between two stones. You can also grind your teeth. So it's physical, it's slow, it's relentless. This is why we have phrases like **the daily grind**, the daily

routine of boring, hard work, and **back to the grind**, meaning returning to that hard work. So the idea of grinding involves friction, effort, and really working hard to achieve your goals.

So we have a nice contrast between our two main words: hustle is about shaking, quick movement, it's fast, whereas grind is slow, it's crushing, and it's wearing something down over time. So, with all that in mind, let's get into the vocabulary.

GRINDING

So, starting with grind. We've seen the daily grind, back to the grind, grinding. We also have the phrase **rise and grind**. This is like a gym slogan that's been popularised in recent years, and it means waking up early and working hard, either training at the gym or going for a run. Rise and grind was a popular slogan among Instagrammers in recent years.

Then there's the **rat race**. This is an excellent, if slightly miserable, image. It refers to the endless, competitive race for money and status, much like rats running in a wheel, going around in circles, and that's part of the daily grind, you're on that wheel.

We also had **burn the candle at both ends**. Now, this is a really nice old expression. If you picture a candle, and instead of lighting it at just one end, you light it at both ends, it burns down twice as fast. And that's what happens when you wake up very early, start working, and don't finish until late at night; you're sacrificing your sleep and your quality of life, you're burning the candle at both ends.

One of my favourite and most-used expressions is **the crack of dawn**, which refers to the very first light of day, the moment dawn arrives, the day breaks, or "cracks" open. I like to use this because when I get a good night's sleep and I get to bed early, I love to wake up at the crack of dawn, get outside, go for a walk and do my morning routine.

BURNING OUT

The next group of words I'd like to explore refer to burning out. The first one is a **workaholic**. As you can imagine, like a chocoholic, alcoholic, shopaholic, these are people who are addicted to something. And a workaholic is someone who cannot say no to work. I guess some of us have been there, some of us are still there, or we know workaholics who are so addicted to something that they just can't give it up, they can't disconnect from work.

Next up is a phrasal verb, to **burn out**. When you burn out, you've burned the candle at both ends for so long that you're completely drained, exhausted, physically and emotionally. The adjective is **burnt out**, and the noun is **burnout**. So you can say, "I feel like I'm going to burn out", or "suffer from burnout." And if you never truly stop, you **run yourself into the ground**, you push so hard that you damage your own health. Imagine you're driving a car and you never get it serviced, never take it to the mechanic's and one day it just falls apart. You run yourself into the ground.

THE BACKLASH

Here's where it gets really current, because the backlash, the response to all of this hustle culture and burnout, is quite positive and gives us some reasons to be hopeful, some silver linings.

The first one is **quiet quitting**. This became popular a couple of years ago, just after COVID, I'd say, and it refers to not quitting your job completely, but doing your job well and no more than that. So you're not working long hours, working over time, staying late for free, answering emails at weekends. You're engaged in quiet quitting, just saying enough is enough, I'm not going to work beyond 5 p.m. today.

Then there's **bare minimum Mondays**, and I love this one. I'm sure, I could probably accuse some of my students of it, and maybe they could accuse me of it too. Bare minimum Mondays means deliberately

taking it easy on a Monday instead of rushing into things, because you know, it's Monday morning and you're still recovering from the weekend. So bare minimum Mondays is a great approach, just easing into the week, because there's a long week ahead and it's better to go softly into the week.

Speaking of softness, we have **the soft life**, which is choosing comfort, calm and ease over ambition, grinding, hustling and the stress that comes with it. This is what I was talking about at the start, Gen Z opting for the soft life and prioritising work-life balance. So quiet quitting, bare minimum Mondays and the soft life, it's all a pushback against **toxic productivity**, which is really another term for hustle culture.

PUSHING BACK

And how do we push back against that toxic productivity? Well, we learn to **switch off**, or **unplug**, which means to mentally step away from work and properly relax. You're not just leaving the office or closing the laptop, you're disconnecting mentally and learning to **recharge your batteries**, so that when you come back to work, or come back from your holiday, you feel refreshed, restored and you're ready to prioritise yourself again ahead of toxic productivity.

So I really like switch off or unplug, and also, **wind down**. Now, wind down is often confused with unwind, and sometimes I have to clarify this for students. To wind down, if you think of "calm down," is quite similar. When you calm down, you reduce your level of excitement, anger or tension. Winding down is about gradually letting go of stress and tension, until the point where you feel totally relaxed. So in the evening, you learn to wind down by taking a bath, reading a book, having a cup of chamomile tea. How do you like to wind down? **Unwind**, means simply means to relax; I unwind by going to the beach. But winding down refers to relaxing after a period of stress or activity. So there we have switch off, unplug, recharge your batteries, and wind down.

OVERLOAD

And finally, the language of overload. When you struggle to wind down, unplug and recharge your batteries, it's often because you have **a lot on your plate**. And unfortunately, not all of us find it so easy to take it easy, because we've got so much on our plate. There will be periods in life where we have to grind a little bit harder, but the important thing is not to prioritise it or not to feel like I shouldn't relax because I have to be productive, I have to be hustling. And with that in mind, remember: **all work and no play** makes Jack a dull boy. OK, so all work and no play is if you don't learn to have fun, let your hair down, rest and enjoy life, then what's the point of any of it?

Okay, folks, that was quite a lot of vocabulary, and quite a lot of me yapping. I hope I haven't bored you, and if I have, well, may be it's helped you to wind down a little bit. If you've missed any of the vocabulary from the lesson, I'll share this PDF, and you can listen back to the podcast and have a glance at the PDF, pick out some personal favourites of yours and try to use them in a real context. So please, don't burn the candle at both ends. I know you might have a lot on your plate, but hustle culture, grinding and toxic productivity is not the most important thing in the world. Hopefully this gives you a lot of food for thought, and you learn to prioritise what's important, which is the soft life and work-life balance.

WRAPPING UP

And that's about it for this week's Johncast. Thank you so much for tuning in. It really means so much to me that you've come back. We had a few podcast episodes last year, and now I'm getting it back and I hope you find it useful. It's short and sweet, and it gives us a chance to listen to some English and pick up interesting bits and pieces of vocabulary. Feel free to share it with students, with friends, and that's it, that's a wrap. It's finished, we're done. OK, so I'll see you next week. Until then, take good care of yourself, don't run yourself into the ground. Stay curious, and keep learning.

HUSTLING

- **hustle culture**
the belief that constant work and busyness is the path to success
- **to hustle**
to work hard and energetically (or get sth by dishonest means)
- **hustle and bustle**
the noise and busy activity of a lively place
- **a side hustle**
small job done alongside your main one to earn extra money

GRINDING

- **to grind**
to work hard and steadily at something boring or tiring
- **the daily grind**
the boring, repetitive routine of everyday work
- **back to the grind**
returning to hard, routine work (often after a break)
- **rise and grind**
get up early and get straight to work; a hustle slogan

PRESSURE

- **the rat race**
the exhausting, competitive struggle for money and status
- **burn the candle at both ends**
to tire yourself by being busy from very early to very late
- **the crack of dawn**
very first light of day; extremely early morning

BURNING OUT

- **a workaholic**
someone addicted to work who can't switch off
- **to burn out**
to become completely drained by prolonged stress or overwork
- **burnout**
the state of total physical and mental exhaustion from overwork
- **run yourself into the ground**
to exhaust yourself completely by pushing too hard

THE BACKLASH

- **quiet quitting**
doing your job and no more, without actually resigning
- **bare minimum Mondays**
deliberately taking it easy at the start of the week
- **the soft life**
choosing comfort, calm and ease over ambition and grind

SWITCHING OFF

- **to switch off**
to stop thinking about work and mentally relax
- **to unplug**
to disconnect from work and technology to rest
- **to wind down**
to gradually let go of stress until you feel relaxed
- **to unwind**
to relax and release tension

OVERLOAD

- **have a lot on your plate**

to have many responsibilities to deal with at once

- **all work and no play**

a life with too much work and not enough fun